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Credit - Drishti Ias

India-US Relations: Strategic Convergence and Energy Diplomacy

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For Prelims: Venezuelan crude oil , Indo-Pacific region , Strait of Hormuz , LEMOA, COMCASA, BECA, and GSOMIA , Artemis Accords

For Mains: India–US bilateral relations, Strategic partnerships, Strategic autonomy, Quad, Indo-Pacific security, India's neighbourhood policy, Reform of multilateral institutions

Source: AIR

Why in News?

The US Secretary of State embarked on a high-profile three-day official visit to India. During the visit, he described India as a **"refining superpower,"** pitched increased exports of **US and Venezuelan crude oil** to help India diversify its energy basket, and underscored that despite tactical differences, India and the US remain **"perfectly aligned on core issues" of national interest.**

Summary

- The US highlighted opportunities for India–US cooperation in Venezuelan and American crude oil, refining, trade and emerging technologies to strengthen India's energy security and economic resilience.
- Despite convergence on Indo-Pacific security, defence and technology, tariff disputes, immigration restrictions and India's strategic autonomy remain key challenges to building a durable India–US strategic partnership.

What are the Key Outcomes of the Visit?

- **Energy Security & Refining Partnership:** The US urged India to leverage its high-complexity refining infrastructure (specifically visiting Reliance Industries' Jamnagar refinery) to process heavy Venezuelan crude and expand imports of US petroleum products.

- **Sanctions Waivers on Russian Oil:** Recognizing global energy vulnerabilities, the US suspended certain sanctions against major buyers of **Russian oil** , including India, to facilitate **market stability and ease supply pressures.**
- **Progress Toward a Bilateral Trade Deal:** Both sides signaled that negotiations on a **comprehensive trade agreement are in their final stages** .
- **Convergence on Emerging Technologies & AI:** Both nations reaffirmed cooperation on **Artificial Intelligence ("Superintelligence")** , agreeing on a shared framework to harness advanced AI for human development while mitigating systemic security risks.
- **Defence & Indo-Pacific Reaffirmation:** Washington pushed for deeper defence procurement ties and reiterated that the 21st-century global order will be defined by peace, stability, and deterrence in the **Indo-Pacific region** .

Significance of Venezuelan Oil

Venezuela possesses the **world's largest proven crude oil reserves** (concentrated in the **Orinoco Heavy Oil Belt**). However, its primary export blend (*Merey*) is **extra-heavy (low API gravity) and sour (high sulphur)** , requiring specialized, capital-intensive refinery equipment (such as delayed cokers) to process.

Dimension	Significance for India	Significance for the US
Energy Security and Diversification	Diversifies crude oil imports beyond Russia and West Asia, reducing exposure to geopolitical tensions and disruptions in the **Strait of Hormuz and Red Sea.**	Expands global oil supply, potentially easing crude oil and diesel prices without relying solely on additional US production.
Refining Economics and Infrastructure	Complex refineries, including Reliance's Jamnagar refinery, can process heavy crude into high-value products, **potentially improving Gross Refining Margins (GRMs).**	Utilises India's refining capacity as a global hub for processing Venezuelan crude into petroleum products for international markets.
Strategic Investments and Upstream Assets	Creates opportunities for **ONGC Videsh Ltd (OVL)** to recover outstanding dividends and revive investments in Venezuelan projects such as San Cristóbal and Carabobo-1, subject to sanctions and contractual approvals.	Strengthens US influence over Venezuelan oil trade while encouraging **India to diversify its crude imports away from Russia** and limiting Venezuela's dependence on China and Iran.

Click here to Read: US Intervention in Venezuela and the Revival of the Monroe Doctrine

What is the India–US Strategic Alignment?

The India–US relationship has evolved from post-Cold War estrangement into a **"Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership."** Rather than a rigid, treaty-bound military alliance, it operates as a **convergent alignment of democracies** driven by shared geopolitical realities, economic complementarity, and technological synergy.

- **Foundational Defence Frameworks:** Operationalized through the four foundational agreements **LEMOA, COMCASA, BECA, and GSOMIA** alongside co-production initiatives like the **INDUS-X** defence innovation bridge and GE F414 jet engine manufacturing.
- **Critical and Emerging Technologies:** Cooperation is advanced through the **US–India TRUST initiative (2025),** which succeeded **iCET (Initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology)** and covers AI, semiconductors, quantum technologies, critical minerals, biotechnology, energy and space (**NISAR , Artemis Accords**) .
- **Minilateral Plurilateralism:** Institutionalized through the **Quad** (India, US, Japan, Australia) in the Indo-Pacific and **I2U2** .

Significance of the Alignment

- **Multipolar Indo-Pacific & Rule-Based Order:** Acts as the primary structural counterbalance to unilateral assertiveness and maritime coercion in the Indo-Pacific, ensuring freedom of navigation along critical **Sea Lines of Communication (SLOCs).**
- **Supply Chain Decoupling & Resilience:** Positions India as a trusted **"China-Plus-One"** manufacturing and technology hub under initiatives like the **Mineral Security Partnership (MSP) and Indo-Pacific Economic Framework (IPEF).**
- **Net Security Provider:** Enhances India's Intelligence, Surveillance, and Reconnaissance (ISR) capabilities along its continental borders and across the **Indian Ocean Region (IOR).**
- **Global South Bridge:** Enables Washington to engage constructively with the Global South through New Delhi's diplomatic credibility, while helping India pitch for reformed multilateralism.

Click here to Read: India–US Relations: Resolving Friction, Building Trust

What are the Persistent Challenges in India–US Strategic Alignment?

- **Trade Protectionism & Tariff Frictions:** Recurring disputes over punitive tariffs, market access in agriculture and dairy, digital trade taxes, and US "America First" reciprocal tariff threats continue to delay a comprehensive Bilateral Trade Agreement.
- **Skilled Mobility & Immigration Curbs:** Steep hikes in **H-1B visa fees** and recent restrictions on key **green-card processing programmes** directly hurt major Indian IT service providers (such as TCS and Wipro) and constrain people-to-people economic integration.
- **Strategic Autonomy vs. Sanctions Regimes:** Friction persists over India's defence and energy ties with **Russia and Iran** (e.g., Chabahar port, S-400 systems, and proposed US secondary sanctions bills on Russian energy buyers).
- **Divergence on Neighbourhood Geopolitics:** Periodic US diplomatic postures regarding **Pakistan (including Washington's claims regarding mediation during the May 2025 India-Pakistan military clashes)** clashes with India's red lines on cross-border terrorism.
- **Regulatory & Technology Transfer Bottlenecks:** Strict US export control regimes (**International Traffic in Arms Regulations (ITAR) and Export Administration Regulations (EAR)**) often slow

down the actual transfer of proprietary military and dual-use technologies despite high-level political clearances.

- **Commercial Hurdles in US and Venezuelan Crude** : High trans-oceanic freight rates caused US crude shipments to India to nearly halve in 2026, while scaling up Venezuelan crude requires navigating lingering US sanctions provisions, payment channels, and degraded Venezuelan upstream infrastructure

What Measures are Needed to Strengthen the India - US Partnership?

- **Institutionalizing "Sanctions-Proof" Energy Corridors:** Establish long-term sovereign waivers and transparent payment-settlement mechanisms so Indian refiners and PSUs can invest in and process Venezuelan crude without facing sudden snapback sanctions.
- **Early Harvest Trade Architecture:** Utilize the current **60-day tariff review window** to finalize a mutually beneficial "Early Harvest" trade deal that locks in predictable tariff rates, resolves non-tariff barriers, and protects service-sector mobility.
- **Carve-Outs for Tech & Talent Mobility:** Create a dedicated **trusted-partner visa and green-card track** under the iCET framework for STEM professionals to insulate technological collaboration from domestic immigration politics.
- **Accelerating Co-Production over Buyer-Seller Models:** Fast-track defence industrial roadmaps by streamlining US Congressional notifications and export licensing for jet engines, unmanned systems, and seabed sensors.
- **Expanding Trilateral & Minilateral Synergy:** Scale up the **India–US–UAE trilateral framework** to operationalize the **IMEC corridor** , linking West Asian capital, Indian refining and digital infrastructure, and U.S. technological leadership.

Conclusion

In a rapidly changing world order, expanding strategic convergence should anchor India–US relations. By combining energy security, technological cooperation and Indo-Pacific alignment, both countries can overcome short-term trade and visa disputes and build a durable, mutually beneficial strategic partnership.

> ***Drishti Mains Question:***
>
> India–US relations have evolved from strategic estrangement to selective strategic convergence. Examine the drivers of this transformation and the challenges to sustaining the partnership.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. Why is Venezuelan oil significant for India?
Venezuela has the world's largest reported proven crude oil reserves, much of it heavy or extra-heavy crude. Its supplies could diversify India's oil imports and create opportunities for complex refineries and Indian energy companies.

2. What is the significance of the Jamnagar refinery in India–US energy cooperation?
Reliance Industries' Jamnagar complex can process a wide range of crude grades. Its refining capabilities could support the processing of suitable Venezuelan crude, subject to commercial viability and applicable sanctions.

3. What are LEMOA, COMCASA and BECA in India–US defence relations?
These foundational agreements facilitate reciprocal logistical support, secure military communications and geospatial information sharing, respectively, strengthening defence interoperability between India and the United States.

4. What is the Initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology (iCET)?
Launched in 2023, iCET aims to deepen India–US cooperation in critical technologies, including semiconductors, artificial intelligence, defence innovation, telecommunications and advanced research.

5. What are the major challenges to India–US strategic alignment?
Key challenges include tariff and market-access disputes, immigration restrictions, India's strategic autonomy, differences over Russian oil and defence ties, and US export-control restrictions on advanced technologies.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ **https://www.youtube.com/embed/Ytfq1rgQ1Xk**]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. Consider the following statements : (2024)

Statement-I : Recently, Venezuela has achieved a rapid recovery from its economic crisis and succeeded in preventing its people from fleeing/emigrating to other countries.

Statement-II: Venezuela has the world's largest oil reserves.

Which one of the following is correct in respect of the above statements?

(a) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct and Statement-II explains Statement-I

(b) Both Statement-I and Statement-II are correct, but Statement-II does not explain Statement-I

(c) Statement-I is correct, but Statement-II is incorrect

(d) Statement-I is incorrect, but Statement-II is correct

Ans: D

Mains

Q. What is the significance of Indo-US defence deals over Indo-Russian defence deals? Discuss with reference to stability in the Indo-Pacific region. **(2020)**

Q. 'What introduces friction into the ties between India and the United States is that Washington is still unable to find for India a position in its global strategy, which would satisfy India's National self-esteem and ambitions'. Explain with suitable examples. **(2019)**

Southeast Asia Haze Crisis: Limitations of AATHP

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Source: BBC

A severe transboundary haze crisis in Southeast Asia in October 2026, driven by forest and peatland fires in Indonesia, has affected neighbouring countries, including Malaysia and Singapore, triggering health emergencies and diplomatic tensions within **ASEAN** . The crisis highlights the enforcement limitations of the **ASEAN Agreement on Transboundary Haze Pollution (AATHP).**

- **Unprecedented Scale:** Over 1 million wildfire hotspots have scorched approximately 900,000 hectares of land in Indonesia, predominantly on the islands of Kalimantan (Borneo) and Sumatra.
  - The primary driver is **"slash and burn" agriculture** —an illegal but widespread practice of using fire as a cheap method to clear forest.

- **Peatland Fires:** Fires in drained peatlands can smoulder underground for prolonged periods, releasing fine particulate matter (PM2.5) and greenhouse gases, making them difficult to control.
  - The annual dry season fires are significantly intensified this year by an **unusually strong El Niño** , a natural climate phenomenon that creates severe drought conditions, making the fires harder to extinguish.
- **Diplomatic Tensions:** The crisis has strained bilateral relations. Singapore initiated action involving 10 Indonesian companies under its **Transboundary Haze Pollution Act, 2014,** which enables legal action against entities responsible for haze affecting Singapore.
  - Indonesia's President condemned **slash-and-burn practices as "ecological terrorism"** and suspended 26 companies' licences, while civil society groups demanded a national disaster declaration.

ASEAN Agreement on Transboundary Haze Pollution (AATHP)

- **About:** Established in 2002 and effective since 2003, the **AATHP** is a legally binding **regional agreement** aimed at preventing and monitoring transboundary haze from land and forest fires through regional cooperation.
  - **Indonesia became the last of the original ten ASEAN members to ratify the agreement in 2015.**
- **Institutional Mechanism:** The agreement provides for the **ASEAN Coordinating Centre for Transboundary Haze Pollution Control (ACC THPC)** to facilitate information sharing, coordination and assistance in managing forest fires and haze.
- **Regional Initiatives:**
  - **Second ASEAN Haze-Free Roadmap (2023–2030):** Aims to achieve a **transboundary haze-free ASEAN by 2030** through improved monitoring, prevention and regional cooperation.
  - **ASEAN Peatland Management Strategy (2023–2030):** Promotes sustainable peatland management, fire prevention and restoration of degraded peatlands.
- **Enforcement Challenges:** Despite its legally binding nature, the AATHP lacks strong regional sanctions and enforcement mechanisms. The **"ASEAN Way," emphasising sovereignty, consensus and non-interference** , limits collective accountability and effective implementation.

Read more: Wildfires

Earthquake Strikes Russia's Kamchatka Peninsula

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Source: DD

Recently, a **magnitude 7.0 earthquake** struck **Russia's Kamchatka Peninsula** at a reported depth of 152 km.

Kamchatka Peninsula

- **Location:** The Kamchatka Peninsula lies in **Russia's Far East, between the Sea of Okhotsk to the west** and **the Pacific Ocean and Bering Sea to the east.**
- **Pacific Ring of Fire** : The peninsula lies within this zone of **intense seismic and volcanic activity,** associated with tectonic plate boundaries.
- **Climate:** Much of the region experiences **harsh subarctic or tundra-like conditions,** contributing to low population density.
- **Tectonic Setting:** The region is **highly earthquake-prone** due to the subduction of the **Pacific Plate beneath the Okhotsk microplate** , commonly treated as part of the larger **North American Plate.**
- **Mountain Ranges** : The two principal mountain ranges are the **Sredinny Range and the Vostochny Range.**
- **Volcanic Activity:** The peninsula contains numerous volcanoes, including the Volcanoes of Kamchatka **UNESCO World Heritage Site** , comprising six protected components.
- **Klyuchevskoy Volcano:** It is the **highest active volcano in Eurasia** and one of the most **active volcanoes on the peninsula** .
- **Major River:** The **Kamchatka River** is the peninsula's principal waterway.
- **Biodiversity:** The region supports exceptional biodiversity, including **salmonid fish, sea otters, brown bears and Steller's sea eagles.**
- **Kuril Archipelago:** The **Kuril Islands** extend from the Kamchatka region towards Japan and are subject to a territorial dispute between Russia and Japan.



Read more: **Kamchatka Peninsula**

LAHDC (Amendment) Regulation, 2026

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Source: TH

The President of India promulgated the **Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Councils (LAHDC) (Amendment) Regulation, 2026,** extending Hill Councils to all eight districts of Ladakh. Subsequently, 100 elected constituencies were notified across the eight councils.

- Meanwhile, the Centre's proposed framework for a UT-level elected body has sparked debate over the **Lieutenant Governor's (L-G)** authority and Ladakh's demand for greater autonomy.

The LAHDC (Amendment) Regulation, 2026:

- **Councils for All Eight Districts:** Hill Councils will be constituted in Leh, Kargil, and the newly created districts: Sankoo, Changthang, Nubra, Sham, Zanskar, and Drass.
- **Rationalization of Seats:** The previous fixed structure of 26 seats per council has been amended. Now, constituencies will range from a minimum of 7 to a maximum of 24, depending on the district's demographic and geographic realities.
- **Inclusive Representation:** The regulation permits the nomination of up to four members from women and unrepresented communities, subject to a ceiling linked to one-sixth of the elected seats.
- **Administrative Parity with Panchayats:** The councils are granted powers equivalent to district-level panchayats under the **Jammu and Kashmir Panchayati Raj Act, 1989.**
- **Election Authority:** The State Election Commission for the UT of Ladakh will have superintendence, direction, and control over these council elections.

The Centre's Proposed "Constitutional and Statutory Framework" (The UT-Level Body):

- **The L-G Veto:** The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) draft explicitly states that any law or regulation passed by the proposed UT-level elected body will only take effect after receiving assent from the Lieutenant Governor.
- **Constitutional Framework:** The proposal envisages a constitutional arrangement under **Article 371** , alongside regulations under **Article 240,** which empowers the President to make regulations for the peace, progress and good government of specified Union Territories, including Ladakh.
- **Unresolved Institutional Questions:** The draft seeks input from civil society on critical issues: whether delimitation should be population-based or area-based, if women’s reservation should be 33% or 50%, and whether the UT body members should be elected directly or indirectly through the LAHDCs.
- **Concerns:** Activists argue that subjecting every law of the newly proposed UT body to an L-G veto reduces the elected representatives to an advisory role, falling far short of the substantive legislative autonomy guaranteed under the **Sixth Schedule** .
  - The sweeping changes do not address the foundational demands of the Ladakhi people: **full Statehood, Sixth Schedule status , a dedicated Public Service Commission (PSC), and**

separate Lok Sabha seats for Leh and Kargil.

Read more: **MHA Proposes New Chapter K Under Article 371 for Ladakh**

India Calls for Stronger Safeguards Against WMD Proliferation

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Source: DD

Recently, India called for stronger safeguards against **Weapons of Mass Destruction (WMD)** proliferation and terrorist access to sensitive technologies during the discussion on **“Other Weapons of Mass Destruction”** at the **United Nations General Assembly's First Committee.**

- **India’s Position:** India reaffirmed its commitment to the full, effective and non-discriminatory implementation of the **Chemical Weapons Convention (CWC)** **and** **Biological Weapons Convention (BWC)** **,** emphasising stronger international cooperation to address emerging WMD threats.
- **Emerging Technologies:** Scientific and technological advancements pose proliferation risks through the potential misuse of **dual-use technologies** , which have both civilian and military applications.
- **India-Sponsored UN Resolution:** Since 2002, India has introduced the UNGA resolution **“Measures to prevent terrorists from acquiring weapons of mass destruction”** , advocating stronger national and international measures to prevent terrorist access to WMDs and their delivery systems.
- **India's Domestic Safeguards:** India has established legal and export-control mechanisms against WMD proliferation, including the **Weapons of Mass Destruction and their Delivery Systems (Prohibition of Unlawful Activities) Act, 2005** , and controls on sensitive dual-use materials and technologies.
- **Chemical Weapons Convention (CWC):** Entered into force in **April 1997** , it aims to eliminate chemical weapons and prohibits their **development, production, acquisition, stockpiling, retention, transfer and use** . **India is a State Party** , having ratified it in 1996.
- **Biological Weapons Convention (BWC):** Entered into force in **March 1975** , it prohibits the **development, production, acquisition, stockpiling, retention and transfer of biological and toxin weapons** , with the objective of excluding their use as weapons. **India is a State Party** , having ratified it in 1974.
- **UNSC Resolution 1540 (2004):** Adopted under **Chapter VII of the UN Charter** , it requires states to establish effective laws and domestic controls to prevent **non-state actors from acquiring nuclear, chemical and biological weapons and their delivery systems** .
- **UN General Assembly First Committee:** Also known as the **Disarmament and International Security Committee** , it addresses disarmament, international security and related global threats.
- **Significance:** Stronger safeguards and international cooperation can **reduce WMD proliferation risks, prevent terrorist access to dangerous technologies and strengthen the global disarmament and non-proliferation framework** .

Read more: **Weapons of Mass Destruction and their Delivery Systems (Prohibition of Unlawful Activities) Amendment Bill, 2022**